

25 years of spinning the web!



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"But is the web dealing with a quarter life crisis? We would be naive to think that everything on the web was hunky dory."

To this day, I remember the exact moment of my first encounter with the World Wide Web. It was at a friend's place – who much to my envy had managed to cajole his father into getting him a PC with "dial-up internet" connection slightly before I could successfully sucker my own father into it. And although out of my pre-adolescent pride I vowed never to see my friend's face ever again, my curiosity got the better of me. I was amazed with the whole dial-up connection process and the popping up of IE to display Yahoo's homepage, signalling the successful link to the internet. It remains one of my most cherished memories, rivalled only by my other first encounter with a true tech marvel – a 3D printer. Even all those years ago, the internet – and the world wide web in it – didn't reveal the scale of its impact it'd have on my life.

Of course, the web has transformed into an entity beyond anyone's wildest imaginations – surpassing even Arthur C. Clarke's prediction of all-pervasive, internet-connected personal computers. It has disrupted markets, created new ones, brought the world and the human race closer than ever before in any time in history. People don't read newspapers anymore but websites and web feeds; from browsing websites on PCs to apps on smartphones and tablets; from shopping at brick and mortar stores to clicking a button and ordering goods/services online. The web has changed us. From Yahoo and Google to social networks like Facebook and Twitter, we have fundamentally altered the way we find information and communicate with others of our species.

On the heels of companies that expanded the scope of the web, came companies that added software and services on the web's infrastructure, and now we are entering a phase of the web (and the internet) that's increasingly making it all-pervasive and invisible. The number of people I encounter who've never heard a phone's dial tone, or don't remember a pre-internet world (because they weren't born in it), is steadily increasing. Digital natives for whom the web is the same as air and water. All of this in a quarter of a century. Wow, would be an understatement, don't you think?

But is the web dealing with a quarter life crisis? We would be naive to think that everything on the web was hunky dory.

Spam continues to wreak havoc on the web's infrastructure, despite Bill Gates' infamous 2004 prediction that "spam will be gone in two years." Similarly, after Edward Snowden's NSA leaks, Columbia Journalism Review's 1995 prediction of "the web means the end of Big Brother" couldn't be light years away from reality as we know it today. The web's scope and magnitude is so huge that countries and companies have now started to put up fences to regulate access to it. The web's "wild wild west" days are all but over, as it's set to become more mature. Let's hope that in the process it doesn't fully extinguish the spark that ignited it in the first place, and the founding principles governing its birth.

But let's not be overcautious and get carried away with cynicism. The web's story is still unfolding in front of our eyes, and from where I can see it's full of limitless possibilities.

All of us born before the mid '90s have seen the web evolve and expand in front of our eyes, and we've evolved along with it. Countless pen strokes and keystrokes have chronicled Tim Berners-Lee's idea of a hypertext web and how it came to be, so I won't repeat the same here. It's time to just sit back and tip your hat to the web, and where it's taken thus far. And the exciting journey all of us still have to embark upon in the web's unknown yet exciting future. 🇮🇳